

Composition II Story

Revisited

"Death is only one phone call away."—that's what the first line of the textbook said. It was no ordinary textbook; No, rather it was—as the title proudly stated—the "First-Edition, Gold-Lined, Comprehensive Guide to Summoning the Dead". As Mort shut the volume, he reflected just how true the book's contents really were. Just the previous day, Mort had revived his dead daisy. It had been an exhilarating moment when the aspiring sorcerer had accomplished what was deemed "nearly impossible" by the best of his trade. However now, as Mort sat at his cluttered desk, he wasn't gazing at the bright flower; Instead, he was staring at a family picture inside a dusty frame. In particular, Mort was reminiscing about his long-gone brother. Tragically, Wilson had passed away four years ago at the age of eighteen. Mort missed his brother so much. A pain in his side materialized every time he thought about him...yet this time there was another feeling too. There was hope.

That evening, Mort gathered the materials he knew he would need for the summoning. According to the death book, he needed to do the operation at exactly twelve o'clock. If all went to plan, Mort's brother would be eating breakfast with him the next morning. Yet still, in the back of his mind, Mort was afraid. There was good reason for this fear: The country that Mort lived in was ruled by a tyrannical government. Afraid of any treason or rebellion, they observed the civilians' lives as much as they possibly could. The secret police would especially monitor the practice of dark witchcraft. Any misuse of the ancient spells would result in imprisonment, reeducation, or worse. Thus, it was with all stealth that Mort gathered supplies for the unpleasant task.

Mort was in a dreadful state of anxiety and excitement when the heavy knock came on the door. One glance out the front window revealed the awful truth: The police had come. There was no running. Resistance was futile.

"OPEN YOUR DOOR IMMEDIATELY," a deep voice ordered through the front door. It was a voice of which there was no disobeying. "COME OUT WITH YOUR HANDS UP. I REPEAT, THERE IS NO ESCAPE."

Mort slinked over to the door and, shaking, turned the handle. Three men in dark outfits burst into the room as if decency had never been invented. Each held a short dagger, likely coated with dangerous chemicals. Mort cowered in fear, all thoughts of resistance gone out of his head.

"Sir, you are to come with us. Do not make any sudden movements. Put your hands up," The tallest officer commanded.

"What am I being arrested for?" Mort pleaded.

The tall officer smacked Mort across the jaw, which started to bleed. "Quiet! You must remain silent. You are under arrest for treason against the order of the state through the use of dark magic. As is customary you are to be immersed in reeducation as soon as possible." Then with a glance at the officers, "March out!"

Mort's heart sank deep into his stomach. He suspected that reeducation would mean a complete wipe of all his memory. If he was lucky, he would remember who he was. He had earned a chance to bring his brother back—to avenge his early death—but now that chance was lost. Mort had lost. Game over.

The walk to the prison took over an hour. After the journey was over and the prison bars had clanged shut, Mort was exhausted. All his hope was gone. All his energy was gone. All his magic...wait; no, all his magic *wasn't* gone. There was hope. Mort knew that with the right spell, he could get himself out of prison. He could save his memory...save his brother! With hope surging through his veins, Mort racked his mind for a solution to the problem. Finally, he struck upon it: Several months ago he had performed a spell that would teleport him back to a stationary object with the use of a second spell. Unfortunately, he had forgotten the second spell at the time. But now, he remembered it!

Heart racing, Mort slowly said the spell: "Redi ad eum." He repeated the phrase again: "Redi ad eum." He repeated them louder, "Redi ad eum!" Nothing was happening. Now Mort was screaming the words as if sheer

volume could lead to success. Men near his cell started to raise the alarm. They knew that some spells could break a prisoner free. Heavy footsteps echoing down the hallway prophesied doom to Mort's escape plan. "REDI AD EUM!"

Keys turned the lock of the door. *This is it*, thought Mort, *the guards will bust through the door, take me away, and reeducate me. I'll never save my brother, and I'll never be myself again.* The door swung open. To Mort's surprise, no guards burst in. Instead, a tall officer addressed him. "Hello sir, we are afraid there has been a terrible mistake. You are not the man we were looking for. We are very sorry for the inconvenience. You are free to leave."

What?! Mort's head buzzed in a frenzy of disconnected thought. *I'm free? How...why?* Mort felt like he had stepped off a merry-go-round. Everything spun, his lips dried out, and his body plummeted towards the ground. He awoke in thirty seconds to find the men gone and the door open. The guards left no explanation. Mort, gathering his bearings, realized that there was only one thing to do. So he did just that: he walked out. Mort kept walking down the police office hallway, past the front desk, and out the front doors. No one impeded his exit. He strolled down the sidewalks as a free man.

An hour later, Mort stepped through his front door. He still couldn't believe what had happened. What stroke of luck has ripped him from the very jaws of ultimate defeat? His eyes fell on the answer. It was the spellbook. "Why of course!" Mort exclaimed. When he had said the spell, it had certainly acted. But instead of teleporting him, it had warped the guards' minds. They had set him free under his spell.

Mort was free! His eyes roamed over the rooms so dear to him. His brother had once laughed and chatted in these rooms. Mort's eyes fell on the daisy. It was alive and well. Now the thought of the previous day flashed into Mort's head. The possibility came back a hundredfold stronger in his mind. He must go! He must go tonight! He must go *now*!

Quickly gathering the materials, Mort left through his back door. What had the book said? The summoning was to be done at exactly midnight. He

would need to get to the graveyard before then. Once there, he had a strange ritual to perform.

Mort set out on a brisk walk towards the graveyard. The summoning involved water, blood, fire, and magic dust. The young sorcerer had put all these objects into his bag. Fifteen minutes before midnight, as Mort's watch displayed, he arrived at the graveyard. All was dark and shadowy, save for the half-lit moon in the sky above. He fumbled around for several minutes before discovering the grave marked "Wilson". This was the moment of truth: could Mort follow through on the awful ritual? *It's too late to turn back* he told himself. The thing must be followed through on. So, heart beating quickly, Mort began to position the necessary elements.

First, the water was poured onto the gravestone. A ring of gunpowder was poured into the grass around it. With a sharp needle, Mort pricked himself. His blood dropped into the middle of the stone. The awful crimson-pink color smeared over his brother's name, ensuring the magic did its work properly. Finally, Mort sprinkled magic dust over the whole scene. It sparkled in hope of healing a poor soul or making something grow. The gravestone it fell onto suggested otherwise.

Mort nervously stole glances at his watch. Everything was set into place. Only a minute remained before he would light the fire and say the chant. He had no fear of the ritual failing. No, if anything, he was afraid that it *would* work. Mort had an awful, dreadful feeling in his gut. It was more than just excitement; no, he feared that what he was doing was truly *wrong*. Had not his brother died once already? The ticking of his watch distracted him from the pain: it was fifteen seconds until midnight. He must act now.

Mort lit the match. He held it ready to drop. He leaned in closer to the stone. The light pulsed and throbbed menacingly. Then suddenly, its rays illuminated something. It was something Mort had not noticed until then. What was it? Mort peered closer. The match illuminated Wilson's epitaph. The words convicted Mort: "Rest in peace." It was certainly a cliché phrase for a tombstone, but still, it jumped out to Mort. He had never pondered it until then...did not his brother rest peacefully? Who was he to disrupt the sleep of a dead man? It went against the nature of how things should be.

Wilson had traveled to a new world, and Mort was going to kidnap him, grab him back, and force him to relive it all. No, Mort saw things in a different light now: he would not resurrect his brother. He would go back and reform his life. He would no longer dabble in the dark art of magic. The police would never show up at his house again. Once again, he would truly be free.

With this epiphany, Mort looked at his watch. The second hand was moments away from reaching midnight. Suddenly, Mort realized something. He was not holding the match anymore. In the previous seconds, he had dropped it! He looked down and, in horror, saw that the gunpowder was smoking. As the watch clicked to twelve-o'clock, a ring of fire burst out around Wilson's grave. Mort jumped around the fire, trying desperately to stamp it out. The fire rose higher and higher until the tombstone glowed red with the heat. A cloud of mist appeared around the grave, obscuring the scene. Mort staggered back several feet from the mist and watched in dismay.

As the mist dissipated, Mort peered into the cloud, straining his eyes. His heart gave a leap and then a sigh of relief. Nothing had happened. The fire had gone out, the mist was dispersed, and not even the blood remained on the tombstone. All the evidence of his magical excursion was cleared.

Yet better still, Mort's mind was clear. He was okay living in the present. Of course, he still missed his brother, but he wasn't going to let that pain fester. He knew that, with time, the wound would be only a scar. Mort wasn't going to bring back the old times. He was going to forge new ones.